Their goal was to write literature that focused on people's lived realities, especially social issues that affected people's lives.

Ismat Chughtai was born into a large, liberal Muslim family in present-day Uttar Pradesh. She fought against convention to get a BA degree, train as a teacher and then work in Bombay. From the 1930s onwards, she regularly published short stories, novels and essays, and became a popular and pathbreaking writer of Urdu literature. Not only was she a woman writing about women's lives and desires (a subject not often dealt with in the existing literature by men) but she also adopted a direct, frank style full of the everyday language of the community she was writing about. Chughtai often attracted criticism for writing about taboo subjects that were considered 'unsuitable' for a woman to discuss, but, much like her characters, she refused to let social conventions dictate her choices.

MAHASWETA DEVI

1926–2016



Born in present-day Bangladesh, **Mahasweta Devi** was a prolific writer and social activist. For much of her life, she travelled and worked among adivasis, Dalits and marginalized women. Their stories informed the many